

2026 Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam

Day 1: Core

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Question

What array of causal drivers are adduced in the literature to account for different political outcomes in regime type, state form or electoral systems (i.e. dictatorship vs democracy; contrasting cleavage structures; electoral systems). How do theorists deploy history and timing in making their arguments?

Introduction

From the peninsula of Gibraltar,¹ one can see land governed by three distinct states: the Kingdom of Spain, the Kingdom of Morocco, and the United Kingdom.² The landscape is visually quite similar; the boundary between Gibraltar and Spain is purely political, and the seven-mile-wide strait is geologically little more than an advanced valley. Yet, each of these lands has experienced dramatically distinct transitions – or lack thereof – from monarchy to democracy. Spain’s development to liberal democracy famously included an extensive fascist dictatorship; the United Kingdom’s gradual progression to the current Westminster System was significantly more gradual; Morocco is still a monarchy today, even if with some modest constitutional restrictions. Why, then, does this one coastal viewpoint offer such a distinct range of political outcomes across a relatively undistinctive physical landscape?

Identifying political and economic deviations across meager physical boundaries is not a novel perspective within political science or the social sciences more generally; Acemoglu & Robinson (2012) famously employ this framework to counter theories of economic dependence on geographical factors in “Why Nations Fail.” Yet, the question is still an intriguing one that has motivated a significant corner of the social sciences, perhaps none more significantly than comparative politics. By Mill’s (1843) “method of difference,” the relatively identical nature of this physical landscape, compared to the significant variation in sociopolitical outcomes, suggests that the causal factors behind regime outcomes must lie elsewhere. If geography alone does not sufficiently explain the distinction between the human-created institutions

¹So long as one’s southward view is not entirely obscured by the titular Rock

²Of which Gibraltar is an “Overseas Territory”

built upon them, then it indeed must be the case that the driving factors are, to a large extent, humanistic themselves.

In this response, I explore the literature's fundamental discussions of the factors driving political outcomes in regime type, state form, and broadly, political institutions. I present three primary causal arguments, each of which is unique in its approach but not mutually exclusive from the others: (1) a state's historical economic composition and structure; (2) the identity-based composition of the constituency, along with the salience of those identity characteristics; and (3) the chronological timing of modernization processes themselves. I further present a relatively – though admittedly not entirely – conflicting counterargument regarding the innate dependency of political outcomes on randomized or exogenous influences, discussing both its limitations and its possible contributions nonetheless. I close by exploring some various empirical strategies that could be used to further our collective perception of these three (or four) causal relationships. **rewrite this – explore existing and present further**

In discussing and evaluating these arguments, I do not intend to provide a definitive weighting of their relative accuracy or value. To do so would be more than I could hope to reasonably accomplish in an entire career, and would almost certainly involve discarding valuable arguments that may indeed be foundational. Yet, I do explore my own perspectives within these frameworks, largely built upon my personal affinity towards rationalist and institutionalist answers. It is our responsibility as social scientists to pursue those narratives which we believe most effectively explain the world around us, and to consider how those mechanisms might be best employed to construct a more effective political future.

An Economic Explanation

One of the field's driving discussions of political evolution is the role of economic structures and factors. Scholars of this framework broadly posit that the development of contemporary regime types (and the political institutions within them) are a result of the historical amount, distribution, and nature of capital. Yet, the exact ways in which these economic contexts affect long-term political outcomes are quite varied within the literature.

I organize this section into three subsections based on the role of the respective socioeconomic classes: the elites, the middle class, and the poor. As with this response in its entirety, these explanations are not mutually exclusive: an argument for the role of the wealthy does not inherently negate³ the role of the poor. In fact, as we shall see, many of these factors are both complementary and reinforcing.

The Elites: A Power-Sharing Balance

The evolving role of the elites in political development is, to say the least, curious. Historical social orderings generally included an exclusive elite with much greater influence in social, political, and economic affairs than their middle-or-lower-class counterparts. Yet, liberal democracy invokes norms of “representativeness, accountability, equality, and participation” (Lijphart 1991), inherently opposed to the existence of a disproportionately-influential class. This suggests that an ultimate transition to liberal democracy must involve a transition away from this influence; likewise, an inability to facilitate this transition will likely result in some

³On occasion, some do; I discuss this as appropriate.

alternative outcome. The central puzzle in democratic development, as (Ziblatt 2017) puts it, is what might have resulted in this relinquishing of influence, including whether it happened peacefully or through violence.

Let us first consider the seminal work of Barrington Moore, whose (1966) “Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy” explores (among other topics) the role of the elites in differentiating between democratic, fascist, and communist outcomes. Moore delineates between two general arrangements of the aristocracy: a dependence on the state, or a dependence on the market. If the aristocracy’s wealth was primarily derived from the state – be that sharing in its political rents, employment or appointment to prestigious posts, or similar dependencies – the state would accordingly possess an excess of influence over this class, frequently leading to royal absolutism. This, in turn, largely prevented any transition to even infantile democracy: either the state was powerful enough to retain its absolute authority, or the elites would be empowered to revolt and establish an extractive regime framed by (Boix 2003) as “right-wing authoritarianism.” Conversely, as Moore posits, a power-sharing equilibrium between the crown and the elites was an early prerequisite for democracy and could facilitate both the peaceful coexistence of the regime and the elites, as well as a peaceful graduation of influence to these aristocrats.

Of course, it is important to consider not just the conditions leading to the enfranchisement of the elite, but also the instigating factors which facilitated this development. A common answer is simply informational – that the elites possess privileged information which the state does not. (Ahmed & Stasavage 2020) discuss the emergence of council governance – the first movements away from total executive authority – as a reflection of informational

asymmetry whereby the elites could extract revenue from the land (and the people) much more efficiently than the state. Indeed, they find support for this hypothesis as it pertains to agricultural production, whereby councils were historically more likely to emerge in societies with significant variability in caloric production.

References

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